

CAR-07 · CAREER ROADMAP

# Building a portfolio of evidence

What evidence of controls work actually looks like, and how to describe it without breaching confidence



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PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.

AI proposes. The professional disposes.

## — Summary

A curriculum vitae asserts; a portfolio demonstrates. This document gives a five-part structure for an evidence record, a graded scale from presence to ownership, an inventory of where evidence appears in an ordinary reporting month, and — the part most people get wrong — a method for anonymising a case properly, including why anonymisation fails on combinations of details rather than on names, and how to index figures so the teaching survives while the confidential magnitudes do not.

## — About this document

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# Contents

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|                                                                            |    |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|----|
| 1. Why a portfolio, not a longer CV .....                                  | 4  |
| 2. The unit of evidence.....                                               | 4  |
| 3. The scale that matters: presence, contribution, ownership, change ..... | 5  |
| 4. Where the evidence already is .....                                     | 5  |
| 5. Confidentiality: what you may not take, and the test to apply .....     | 6  |
| 6. Anonymising a case properly.....                                        | 6  |
| 7. Verification without disclosure.....                                    | 7  |
| 8. Structuring the portfolio itself .....                                  | 7  |
| 9. How this goes wrong .....                                               | 8  |
| 10. Worked example — one record, before and after anonymisation.....       | 8  |
| 11. Checklist — the portfolio audit.....                                   | 9  |
| Related .....                                                              | 10 |
| Sources and standards.....                                                 | 10 |
| Status and version .....                                                   | 10 |

# Building a portfolio of evidence

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**In one paragraph.** A curriculum vitae asserts what you did; a portfolio demonstrates what you decided, what changed because of it, and how you know. This document gives a five-part structure for an evidence record, a scale that distinguishes presence from ownership, an inventory of the evidence an ordinary reporting month already produces, and a seven-step method for anonymising a case — including the failure that catches most people, which is that anonymisation is defeated by a combination of ordinary details rather than by a name. It ends with a before-and-after anonymisation, worked with arithmetic, showing that the ratios carrying the teaching survive indexation while the confidential magnitudes do not.

**Who this is for.** Cost engineers, planners, risk and change professionals and controls managers building a record of their own work; also hiring managers and assessors deciding what to ask for.

## — 1. Why a portfolio, not a longer CV

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A curriculum vitae lists positions occupied. It answers "where were you" and, by implication, "for how long" — and neither question separates two people with the same title on the same project, one of whom owned the forecast and one of whom formatted the report.

An interviewer, a competency assessor and a client's technical panel want three other things. **What did you decide** — not what the team decided; a decision has an owner, a date and a rejected alternative. **What changed because of it** — a number that moved, an error prevented, a claim defended, a control that stopped a class of failure rather than one instance. **How do you know** — evidence someone else can test, including the record of the times you were wrong. A portfolio is those three questions, answered repeatedly, in a structure someone can read quickly.

## — 2. The unit of evidence

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One record, five parts. Fitting on one page is a feature.

**1. The claim.** One sentence naming the competency and the level. "Owned the forecast at completion for a package of control accounts, including method selection and defence to the project director."

**2. The context.** Enough to make the claim assessable and no more: type of project, contract form, relative scale, your role and reporting line. Not the client, project or contract value — \$5 and \$6 explain why.

**3. The action.** What you personally did, in the first person singular, with the decision explicit and the alternative named. "I selected a performance-persists forecast rather than the one-off-variance basis used the previous cycle, because the shortfall was present in three consecutive cycles and in both the timesheet and the quantity record."

**4. The outcome.** What changed, quantified where it can be quantified without disclosure — proportions, ratios and index points rather than currency. Include outcomes that went against you; they are more persuasive, not less.

**5. The verification.** How a third party could check: a referee by role, a countersignature, an audit reference, an artefact that exists independently of you. §7 covers this.

A record missing part 3 is a job description; a record missing part 5 is an assertion. Both are common and both are discounted immediately by anyone who reads portfolios for a living.

### — 3. The scale that matters: presence, contribution, ownership, change

Weak evidence is usually weak because it sits at the wrong rung of this scale.

| Level        | What it sounds like                                                                                                                                                                           | What it evidences                                         |
|--------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Presence     | "Worked on the monthly reporting cycle"                                                                                                                                                       | That you were there                                       |
| Contribution | "Supported the preparation of the forecast"                                                                                                                                                   | That you were useful                                      |
| Ownership    | "Owned the forecast for eleven control accounts, including method selection, and defended it at the monthly review"                                                                           | That you can be held to an answer                         |
| Change       | "Found that the accrual routine was missing subcontract work certified after cut-off; redesigned it; the correction moved reported cost performance and stopped the understatement recurring" | That the organisation is different because you were in it |

Ownership and change are what get read, and neither can be manufactured when you need it — only captured while it happens. [CMP-02 – Competency levels and how they are evidenced](#) sets out how the Institute levels competence; this is about the record you keep for yourself.

### — 4. Where the evidence already is

An ordinary reporting month generates more evidence than most people record in a year. The inventory:

- the accrual position you established at cut-off, and the judgement you made about an incomplete input;
- the variance narrative you wrote, and the driver you identified before it reached the ledger;
- the change you priced, with the basis, and what happened to it;
- the schedule update narrative and the delta explanation ([CAR-04 §6](#));
- the risk you added that later materialised, or the one you argued to retire;
- the audit finding you responded to, and the control you changed as a result;
- the recovery plan you tested for plausibility, and the reconciliation you ran between two systems that disagreed;
- the template, mapping, rule of credit or automation you built that outlived your involvement;
- the error in your own work that you reported before anyone else found it;
- the forecast you published in advance with a falsification condition ([CAR-03 §6](#)) and how it behaved.

Ten minutes at the end of each cycle, capturing one record from that list, produces a portfolio with nothing reconstructed after the fact — and reconstruction is where accuracy and confidentiality both fail.

## — 5. Confidentiality: what you may not take, and the test to apply

The governing principle is unwelcome and simple: **your employer's and your client's data is not your portfolio.** Yours is your own account of what you decided and why. Not yours: documents, extracts, screenshots, datasets and models, whether or not you personally created them. Specifically, do not disclose:

- the identity of the client, project or contract, unless it is genuinely public and your employer is content; and any value, rate or margin, or anything from which one can be derived;
- unpublished claims, disputes, notices, entitlement positions, or subcontractor pricing;
- personal data about colleagues, including performance, disciplinary and safety matters;
- security-sensitive site, system or asset information, which in some sectors is a legal matter;
- anything under a non-disclosure agreement, and in listed-company contexts anything price-sensitive.

**The three-reader test.** Before a record leaves your possession, ask whether it could be read without harm or embarrassment by the client, by your employer's commercial director, and by a competitor. If any answer is no, it is not ready. That is stricter than "would anyone recognise it", and it is the right test, because harm from disclosure does not require recognition.

Where a conflict is live between what you may say and what you believe should be said, the Institute's treatment is in [ETH-04 – Conflicts of interest in project controls](#).

## — 6. Anonymising a case properly

Most attempted anonymisation removes the name and stops, which is not anonymisation but redaction of the single least informative field. Work through all seven steps.

**Step 1 — remove direct identifiers.** Client, project, contract number, site, joint-venture partners, named individuals. Replace people with roles: "the project director", "the client's quantity surveyor".

**Step 2 — remove the identifying combination.** This is the step that is missed. Sector, region, approximate value, contract form and period, taken together, identify a project to anyone in that market even though no single element names it. The test is not "have I removed the name" but "how many projects in the world match this description". If the answer is a small number, keep generalising: widen the sector descriptor, drop the region, express the period relatively rather than by year.

**Step 3 — index the figures.** Do not round confidential magnitudes; remove them. Choose a base — the budget at completion is usually the natural one — set it to 100, and express every other figure as a proportion of it. State plainly that figures are indexed. \$10 works this through.

**Step 4 — keep the ratios, because they carry the teaching.** Performance indices, variance percentages, proportions of budget, days of movement and productivity factors all survive indexa-

tion. A reader learns nothing from a currency amount they cannot contextualise and everything from an index that moved from 1.09 to 1.00.

**Step 5 — check for re-identification through the incident itself.** A distinctive event — an unusual failure, a well-known dispute, a notable delay — can identify a project more precisely than any figure. Describe its mechanism without the case, or do not use it.

**Step 6 — label the anonymisation.** In the record: "Figures indexed to a budget of 100. Project, client and period not identified. No confidential document is reproduced and no figure can be derived from this record." A reader who can see the discipline you applied trusts the rest more.

**Step 7 — seek permission where it is possible, and record the answer.** For anything more detailed than an indexed record, ask in writing and keep the reply. If refused, record the refusal and use the method-only version. Silence is not consent.

**Where even the indexed case is identifiable, write the method instead.** "How to test whether a recovery claim is plausible" teaches what the case would have taught, cites no project, and can be shown to anyone.

## — 7. Verification without disclosure

Evidence that cannot be checked is an assertion with extra sentences. Three forms disclose nothing: **a referee by role** ("the project controls manager to whom I reported can confirm this", the name supplied privately when needed, never published); **a countersignature**, a line manager signing a competency record, which is what structured development schemes rely on and what [CMP-10 – Assessing competence](#) describes for formal assessment; and **an independent artefact or audit trace**, such as a procedure you wrote that stayed in use, or "this control was tested in an internal audit and the finding closed", referenced by type and period rather than by number.

**Assessed knowledge is the fourth, and it verifies something different.** A credential evidences knowledge against a published standard, examined independently of your employer. PCI's project controls credential is PCL-AI; it is examined, not portfolio-assessed, and PCI is developed with reference to ISO/IEC 17024 personnel-certification principles and is not accredited. Credential and portfolio evidence knowledge and practice respectively, and neither substitutes for the other. A membership grade is a third thing again — a standing, not a certification — and conflating the ladders looks careless.

Continuing professional development records verify differently again, being structured: PCI recertification runs on a three-year cycle with a mandatory AI-currency component, and only approved entries in the current cycle count. The binding volume is [\[CONFIRM: required CPD hours per three-year cycle — the student portal currently shows a 30-hour target, and the binding requirement will be published with the recertification rules\]](#); [CER-08](#) owns the rules.

## — 8. Structuring the portfolio itself

Organise by competency, not by employer: an employer-ordered portfolio makes the reader do the mapping, and readers do not. Use the PCL-AI competency set as the index: project controls governance, cost management, planning and scheduling, earned value management, forecasting and estimate at completion, performance measurement, project risk, commercial and contract controls,

predictive analytics, AI-enabled project controls, digital reporting, automation, responsible AI, and human validation.

One page each, carrying two records at the highest level you can honestly claim and one line naming the gap. That gap line is the most credible thing on the page, because a portfolio with no gaps reads as one its author has never audited.

Keep two versions and only two: a full one, with names, for your own reference and for a conversation under non-disclosure, and a shareable one anonymised by §6. A third, half-anonymised version is how a name eventually escapes. On leaving an employer, capture your own record of decisions and take nothing else — no documents, extracts, data or models. That is a legal boundary in most jurisdictions, and the part you may keep is the only part a future employer values.

## — 9. How this goes wrong

**Writing it at the end.** Portfolios assembled during a job search are vague about the details that matter — the date, the alternative rejected, the number before and after — because those were never captured and cannot now be reconstructed honestly.

**Claiming the team's work.** "We reduced the forecast" evidences nothing about you. Assessors probe collective verbs first.

**Removing the name and calling it anonymised.** Step 2 of §6 is the step that gets skipped, and the result is a portfolio that identifies a client project to every reader in the sector while its author believes it is discreet. Its close relative is rounding rather than indexing: a rounded budget still discloses the magnitude, which is usually the confidential part.

**Including a document.** A report screenshot, a register page, a model extract — all the employer's property regardless of who typed them, and any one of them converts a professional record into a disclosure incident.

**Only recording successes.** Unbroken correctness is not believed, because nobody who forecasts has that record. A documented wrong forecast, with what you learned and changed, is stronger evidence of judgement than three correct ones — and a list of software proficiencies weaker than either.

## — 10. Worked example — one record, before and after anonymisation

Illustrative figures. Currency-neutral, one control period. Assumptions: progress measured to agreed rules of credit; the accrual identified was the complete un-invoiced position at cut-off; no change approved in the period.

**The confidential version — accurate, and unpublishable.**

On the [named client, named project], budget at completion 42,000,000, I identified at the October cut-off that subcontract liabilities of 1,260,000 had not been accrued. Earned value at that date was 15,000,000 against invoiced cost of 13,800,000.

The arithmetic. Cost performance index before correction = earned value ÷ actual cost = 15,000,000 ÷ 13,800,000 = **1.087**. Actual cost with the accrual booked = 13,800,000 + 1,260,000



= **15,060,000**. Index after =  $15,000,000 \div 15,060,000 = \mathbf{0.996}$ . One entry moved reported performance from 8.7 % above parity — work earned exceeding cost incurred — to marginally below it.

**The anonymised version — publishable, and it teaches the same lesson.**

On a lump-sum industrial project, in its construction phase, I owned the accrual position for a package of control accounts. At a month-end cut-off I identified that subcontract liabilities equal to **3.0 index points** of the budget had not been accrued. Earned value at that date stood at **35.7 index points** against invoiced cost of **32.9**. Booking the accrual moved the reported cost performance index from **1.085 to 0.994** — from apparently earning more than it was spending to marginally the reverse — on a single entry. I subsequently redesigned the cut-off routine so that subcontract work certified after the invoicing deadline is captured by default. Figures indexed to a budget at completion of 100; project, client and period not identified; no confidential document is reproduced.

**Checking the indexation.** Base = budget at completion = 42,000,000 = 100 index points. Earned value:  $15,000,000 \div 42,000,000 \times 100 = \mathbf{35.7}$ . Invoiced cost:  $13,800,000 \div 42,000,000 \times 100 = \mathbf{32.9}$ . Accrual:  $1,260,000 \div 42,000,000 \times 100 = \mathbf{3.0}$ . Index before:  $35.7 \div 32.9 = \mathbf{1.085}$ , against 1.087 computed on the raw figures. Index after:  $35.7 \div (32.9 + 3.0) = 35.7 \div 35.9 = \mathbf{0.994}$ , against 0.996 on the raw figures.

The drift of two thousandths in each index is rounding introduced by publishing indexed values to one decimal place, and it changes nothing a reader would conclude. That is the test of a good anonymisation: the magnitudes are gone and unrecoverable, the ratios are intact to within stated rounding, and the lesson — that one missed accrual can move a position across the line between earning and overspending — is as instructive as in the confidential version.

**What else went, and why.** The budget, as the identifying magnitude; the named month, because a cut-off calendar is a fingerprint; and the specific process industry, widened to "industrial", per step 2.

## — 11. Checklist — the portfolio audit

- Every record has all five parts in §2, is written in the first person singular, and names the decision and the alternative rejected.
- At least half your records sit at ownership or change on the scale in §3, and at least one describes something you got wrong and what changed as a result.
- No record contains a client name, project name, contract value, rate, margin or extract of a document.
- Every case has been through all seven anonymisation steps, not only step 1, and every figure is indexed to a stated base with the indexation labelled.
- You have applied the three-reader test in §5 to the shareable version.
- Permissions sought are recorded, including refusals.
- The portfolio is indexed by competency, with a stated gap on each page.
- You captured at least one record in the last reporting cycle.

The cost of skipping it is paid later and in full: by the time you need the evidence, the project has finished and the people who could verify it have moved, leaving a job title and a date — which is exactly what everyone else in the room also has.

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## — Related

- [CAR-01 – The project controls career roadmap](#) — the transitions this evidence demonstrates
- [CAR-03 – Cost engineer to cost manager](#) — the forecast record described in §4
- [CAR-05 – Into project controls leadership](#) — movement bridges as leadership evidence
- [CMP-02 – Competency levels and how they are evidenced](#) — how the Institute levels competence
- [CMP-10 – Assessing competence: evidence, rubrics, moderation](#) — formal assessment, not a personal portfolio
- [CER-08 – Recertification, CPD and the AI-currency requirement](#) — the rules behind the §7 placeholder
- [ETH-04 – Conflicts of interest in project controls](#) — when confidentiality becomes conduct

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## — Sources and standards

Drawn from the PCI Body of Knowledge, principally Domain 4 (performance management, variance analysis and management reporting), Domain 5 (cost management and cost control) and Domain 6 (earned value management and forecasting); and from the PCL-AI competency set, used as the portfolio index in §8. Confidentiality guidance is stated as principle, not as the law of any jurisdiction: disclosure obligations, employment terms and data-protection rules vary, and a specific case must be checked against the applicable contract and law. No external market, salary or demand data has been used.

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## — Status and version

Founding-stage document · Version 1.0 · draft · Reviewed under PCI governance. PCI makes no claims of accreditation or recognition beyond what is true today.